



Just two problems: Osaka, now ranked 134, hadn't beaten a top-10 opponent since January 2020 and had never advanced past the third round at Roland Garros.

Since returning to the Tour in January after a 15-month hiatus due to maternity leave, the rusty, 26-year-old Japanese compiled a mediocre 13-9 match record. Osaka had to feel encouraged though by defeating No. 21 Caroline Garcia at Qatar, No. 15 Liudmila Samsonova at Indian Wells, and No. 17 Elina Svitolina at Miami — all in straight sets but on hard courts. Equally impressive, the former world No. 1 easily defeated No. 11 Daria Kasatkina and No. 20 Marta Kostyuk at the Italian Open on clay.

Osaka caught a break when her highly anticipated French Open second-round match against Swiatek was played under the roof due to the rain. And she took full advantage of it, never temporising just like during her 2018–21 prime. In the opening set, Naomi had a set point at 4-5, 30-40

but overhit a backhand deep and eventually lost a tiebreaker and the set, 7-6.

She overwhelmed Swiatek 6-1 in the second set, and when she surged to a 4-1 lead in the decider, *Tennis Channel* analyst Lindsay Davenport said, "Osaka has made this clay court look like a hard court. And that's not easy to do when you're playing the best clay-courter." When the Japanese went ahead 5-2, Davenport noted, "It's been remarkable to see Osaka play at this high level for more than two hours."

But could she sustain it?

Superb under pressure until then, Osaka finally succumbed to nerves as she served for the match at 5-3. On match point, Swiatek pounded a serve return that forced a backhand error. Osaka missed two more backhands to get broken.

"Osaka froze ever so slightly, and that was all Swiatek needed to turn it around," said Davenport. Swiatek won the last five games to complete the 7-6, 1-6, 7-5 triumph, one of the

Battle of the giants: Naomi Osaka put up a great fight against Swiatek in the second round, but lost the last five games of the deciding set. REUTERS

greatest comebacks in her career.

The Queen of Clay looks almost unbeatable at Roland Garros where she's now compared to her girlhood idol, The King of Clay — Rafael Nadal.

With characteristic modesty, Swiatek brushed off the comparison. "We'll see in 14 years if the journey is similar. I would never expect anybody to compare me to Rafa because for me he's above everybody, and he's a total legend. I'm proud of myself that I'm playing consistently here and that I'm mentioned in the same sentence as Rafa. That's cool."

A more realistic goal for the 23-year-old Pole is surpassing all-time great Chris Evert's seven Roland Garros titles. "I have the record, but she is the best clay court player, bar none," said Evert. "I have no doubt she'll break my record."